



possessing them. That means we can regulate ourselves. My hope is we will do the same with AI. We could destroy the world with AI, but I think we will end up using it for good causes.



What are your thoughts on rankings of educational institutions and their relevance?

If we didn't have rank-

ings, we would have to invent some. They are not perfect, but they are necessary—some even call them a necessary evil.

If I go to the bank for a loan, the bank checks my creditworthiness. Rankings are akin to the creditworthiness of a university.

But if you live only by rankings, you will die by rankings. Institutions should focus on what

they need to do that organically translates into higher rankings.

At McGill, we have an obsessive commitment to excellence in teaching and research. Our mission statement says research must be measured by the best international standards, period.

If you pursue research simply to go up in rankings, that is wrong. But if you pursue excellence, it

will be recognised. Outstanding research gets read, cited, acknowledged and leads to applications, and that influences ranking metrics.

Rankings are also relative. You can improve but still fall because someone else rises faster. That is partly what I mean by living by rankings and dying by rankings.



What defining moments shaped your career?

What helped me? A flexible approach to learning and curiosity. When I had options, I often chose the riskiest—also the most exciting. People saw risk; I saw excitement.

And having grown up in India—a complex society with many languages, religions and diverse regions—teaches you cognitive flexibility. That helps you navigate complex situations later in life.



What makes Indian managers successful globally?

One key factor, in my view, is the ability to live with complexity—making sense of it and having the cognitive flexibility to think at multiple levels simultaneously. That is our strength, and it is very likely the factor that helped so many people of Indian origin succeed on the global stage. **BT**

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